

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 11

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A night-bus driver describes his final shift before retirement, the strangers he ferries between one and four in the morning, and the quiet way an ordinary career ends.

1

The depot smelled, as it had smelled for thirty-one years, of diesel, damp upholstery, and the burnt-coffee end of a vending machine that nobody had ever quite repaired. I clocked in at half past midnight, signed for the keys of Bus 47, and walked the length of her in the half-dark, tapping the tyres out of habit. The night supervisor said nothing about the date. I had not expected him to. We were not, in this depot, sentimental men.

2

The route had not changed since the year my eldest daughter was born. Out of the depot, left at the wet market, three stops along the old hospital road, then a long, looping descent through the housing estate where the lamps wore yellow halos in the drizzle. I knew every junction the way one knows the rooms of an old house — without looking, without thinking. The bus, too, knew the route. She leaned a little into the third corner before I asked her to.

3

My passengers, between one and four in the morning, were not the passengers of the daylight. They were nurses in flat shoes at the end of double shifts; cleaners with their headphones turned up against the loneliness; one elderly gentleman who travelled the full loop, every Tuesday, simply because he could not sleep. There was a young woman who boarded at the hospital stop, always carrying a small bouquet of unspectacular flowers, and who always got off, alone, two stops before the cemetery. I had carried her every Tuesday for almost a year, and we had never exchanged a word. We did not need to.

4

At a little after two, the trouble I had been half-expecting climbed aboard at the petrol station. He was a heavy man, no longer young, with the careful, dignified walk of someone who had drunk more than he

had meant to. He paid his fare, sat at the back, and began, slowly and methodically, to disagree with the world. The world, in this case, was an advertisement above the rear window for a brand of insurance. He told it, in a voice that filled the whole bus, exactly what he thought of it.

5

I pulled the bus over at the next stop, where the streetlight was strong, and I did not turn the engine off. I walked the length of the aisle the way one walks towards a strange dog: slowly, without sudden movements, with my hands where he could see them. I sat down across from him, one seat away, and I asked him, quietly, where he was going home to. He told me. I asked him whether his wife would be worried. He looked at me for a long moment, and the anger went out of his face the way air goes out of a tyre. He said, very quietly, that she had passed three months ago. I nodded. I did not say I was sorry. I said that I would make sure he got to his stop, and that he should sit a little nearer the front, where the heater worked. He moved without arguing. He slept the rest of the way.

6

By four o'clock the bus was empty. I drove the last leg of the loop without passengers, watching the city rearrange itself for the morning: the bread vans at the bakeries, the first office cleaners letting themselves in with little jangling keys, the sky over the eastern flyover going from black to a thin, washed grey. I took the third corner gently, the way the bus had taught me to. Nobody in the world was watching me do my job correctly for the last time, and that, I realised, was exactly the way I wanted it.

7

I parked Bus 47 in her bay at twenty past five. I wiped down the dashboard, emptied the small bin behind my seat, and folded my jacket over the back of the driver's chair, the way I had folded it on ten thousand other mornings. The supervisor was on his phone. He raised a hand without looking up. I raised one back. I walked across the wet yard with the keys in my pocket, stopped at the gate, and turned, just once, to look at her. She sat under the strip lights, patient and unbothered, ready for whoever would drive her tomorrow.

8

I did not know, then, whether what I felt was sadness or relief or some third thing for which there is no word in any language I know. I knew only that the air outside the depot tasted the way air tastes after rain, and that, somewhere down the long road I had driven for thirty-one years, a young woman would be boarding a bus tonight with a small bouquet of unspectacular flowers, and a stranger at the wheel would carry her, without a word, two stops short of the cemetery, and would never know that she had once been mine.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says that he and the supervisor “were not, in this depot, sentimental men.” Explain, in your own words, what this tells us about the **atmosphere** of the depot on his last morning. [2]

2. Give **one** detail from Paragraph 1 which shows that the narrator's actions are guided by long habit rather than by thought. [1]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator writes that he knew the route “the way one knows the rooms of an old house.” Explain the effect of this comparison. [2]

4. The narrator says, “She leaned a little into the third corner before I asked her to.” What does this sentence suggest about the **relationship** between the driver and his bus? [2]

From Paragraph 3

5. The narrator describes the young woman with the flowers and says, “We did not need to.” Explain what this suggests about **both** of them. [2]

From Paragraph 4

6. The narrator says the troublesome passenger had “the careful, dignified walk of someone who had drunk more than he had meant to.” What is **unusual** about pairing the words **dignified** and **drunk**, and what does the description suggest about the narrator’s view of the man? [2]

From Paragraph 5

7. The narrator says he walked towards the angry passenger “the way one walks towards a strange dog.” Explain how this comparison helps the reader picture the scene. [2]

8. The narrator says “the anger went out of his face the way air goes out of a tyre.” Explain how this image makes the change in the man feel **gradual** and **complete**. [2]

9. Why do you think the narrator says he “did not say I was sorry”? [1]

From Paragraphs 6 and 7

10. The narrator says, “Nobody in the world was watching me do my job correctly for the last time, and that, I realised, was exactly the way I wanted it.” What does this tell us about the narrator’s **character**? [2]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [2]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on the decline of independent local newspapers, the rise of “news deserts”, and the experiments now under way to keep local journalism alive.

1

Twenty years ago, a town of any reasonable size in Britain or the United States could expect to be served by at least one independent local newspaper — a modest, often family-owned weekly or daily whose reporters knew the magistrates by their first names, attended the planning committee out of sheer habit, and printed the school sports results without complaint. Today, that paper is, in a great many towns, gone. A study by the Medill School of Journalism reported in 2023 that more than 2,500 local American newspapers had closed in the previous two decades, and that roughly one in five American citizens now lives in what researchers call a “news desert” — a community with little or no professional local news coverage at all.

2

The economic forces are not, on the face of it, mysterious. Classified advertising, once the steady financial spine of the local press, has migrated almost entirely to free online platforms. Display advertising has followed display readers onto the screens of two American technology companies that capture, between them, roughly half of all digital ad spending. Print circulation has halved, and halved again. Faced with these arithmetic realities, the owners of local papers have responded in the ways that owners do: by cutting reporters, then sub-editors, then whole sections, then whole mastheads. The remaining newsroom of a typical small-town daily is often a single, exhausted journalist with three beats and a part-time photographer.

3

What is lost when a local paper closes is rarely understood until it is already gone. Researchers at the University of Notre Dame found, in a much-cited 2019 paper, that municipalities which lost their daily newspaper subsequently borrowed money at higher interest rates — about ten basis points higher, on average — because investors no longer trusted that local officials were being watched. Voter turnout in local elections, separate studies suggest, falls measurably in news deserts. Civic associations report greater difficulty recruiting volunteers. None of this is glamorous, and none of it makes the front pages of the national press; but in the slow, unspectacular work of holding a town’s small powers to account, the local paper turns out to have been doing rather more than anyone had noticed.

4

Into this vacuum has rushed, inevitably, the citizen reporter. Armed with a smartphone and a social media account, a single resident can today break a story — a flooded road, a council meeting gone awry, a beloved teacher’s retirement — to thousands of neighbours within minutes. Some of this work is excellent, and a few of its practitioners have, by sheer grit, kept their communities informed when no paid journalist remained. Yet most observers agree that volunteer reporting, valuable as it is, cannot substitute fully for the patient, disciplined, often tedious work of professional local journalism. Citizen reporters are not, as a rule, trained in libel law, fact-checking, or the dispiriting craft of sitting through a four-hour planning meeting in order to extract three accurate paragraphs.

5

Worse, the social-media feed which now delivers most local news to most local readers is a poor substitute for the front page. It is, by design, optimised for outrage rather than accuracy, and it rewards the loudest voice rather than the most informed one. A 2021 study by the Reuters Institute found that residents in news deserts were noticeably more likely to hold sharply polarised views about their own town councils,

and noticeably less likely to be able to name their own mayor. A newspaper, for all its faults, was at least a **shared** document; a feed, by contrast, is bespoke to each reader, and divides as readily as it informs.

6

Several experiments are now under way to replace what has been lost. Some local papers have reconstituted themselves as non-profits, supported by foundations, philanthropic readers, and occasional university grants. Others have adopted reader-funded models, in which subscribers pay not for “access” — the paywall having proved, on a small scale, mostly ruinous — but for the survival of the institution itself. The most-cited success story, **The Texas Tribune**, employs more state-house reporters than any commercial competitor and operates almost entirely on donations and event income. Such ventures remain fragile. They depend on a level of civic generosity that, even in the most public-spirited communities, cannot be assumed.

7

The deeper question, which the closures and the experiments together force us to confront, is whether a town that no longer reads about itself can continue, in any meaningful sense, to **be** a town. A community without a common record — a single, agreed-upon weekly account of who was born, who was buried, who built what, who voted how — is a community without a memory and, increasingly, without a conversation. The local paper was never glamorous. It was, in the strictest sense, mundane. But its mundanity, we are now learning, was the slow scaffolding on which civic life had been resting all along.

From Paragraph 1

12. In Paragraph 1, the writer says that local newspaper reporters “attended the planning committee out of sheer habit, and printed the school sports results without complaint.” What does this description tell us about the **attitude** of these reporters towards their work? [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** economic reasons why local newspapers have lost their main sources of income. [2]

14. The writer says that the remaining newsroom of a small-town daily is “often a single, exhausted journalist with three beats and a part-time photographer.” Explain, in your own words, what this suggests about the **state** of small-town journalism today. [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. Explain, in your own words, **one** practical consequence that researchers have found in towns which have lost their local newspaper. [2]

16. The writer ends Paragraph 3 by saying that local papers had been “doing rather more than anyone had noticed.” What is the **effect** of placing this observation at the end of the paragraph? [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. Why does the writer place the words “tedious” and “dispiriting” in his description of professional journalism? [2]

From Paragraph 5

18. The writer says a newspaper “was at least a **shared** document; a feed, by contrast, is bespoke to each reader.” Explain, in your own words, the **contrast** the writer is drawing. [2]

From Paragraph 6

19. Why does the writer place the word “access” in inverted commas? [1]

20. What is the writer’s **tone** when he says that non-profit ventures “depend on a level of civic generosity that, even in the most public-spirited communities, cannot be assumed”? [1]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer ends the text by saying the local paper’s “mundanity... was the slow scaffolding on which civic life had been resting all along.” Explain what is **effective** about the writer’s use of the word **scaffolding**. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **what is lost when a local newspaper closes**, and **the attempts now being made to replace it**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 3 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

When a local newspaper closes, the community loses ...

— END OF PAPER —